MIL-B-44055A
30 September 1983
SUPERSEDING
MIL-B-44055
30 December 1982

MILITARY SPECIFICATION

BEEF, DICED, WITH GRAVY, THERMOSTABILIZED FOR MEAL, READY-TO-EAT

This specification is approved for use by all Departments and Agencies of the Department of Defense.

1. SCOPE

1.1 Scope. This document covers thermostabilized diced beef with gravy in flexible pouches for use as a component of the meal, ready-to-eat, individual.

2. APPLICABLE DOCUMENTS

2.1 Government documents. Unless otherwise specified, the following documents of the issue in effect on date of invitation for bids or request for proposal, form a part of this document to the extent specified herein.

SPECIFICATIONS

FEDERAL

N-[illegible]481	-	Flour, Wheat
EE-B-575	-	Bouillon (Soup and Gravy Base)
JJJ-S-30	-	Salad Oil, Vegetable

MILITARY

MIL-P-44073	-	Packaging and Thermoprocessing of Foods in Flexible Pouches

STANDARD

MILITARY

MIL-STD-105	-	Sampling Procedures and Tables for Inspection by Attributes

Beneficial comments (recommendations, additions, deletions) and any pertinent data which may be of use in improving this document should be addressed to: U.S. Army Natick Research and Development Laboratories, Natick, MA 01760 by using the self-addressed Standardization Document Improvement Proposal (DD Form 1426) appearing at the end of this document or by letter.

FSC 8940

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(Copies of documents required by manufacturers in connection with specific acquisition functions should be obtained from the contracting activity or as directed by the contracting officer.)

OTHER GOVERNMENT DOCUMENTS

U.S. DEPARTMENT OF HEALTH AND HUMAN SERVICES

Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act and Regulations Promulgated Thereunder (21 CFR Parts 1-199)

(Application for copies should be addressed to the Superintendent of Documents, U.S. Government Printing Office, Washington, DC 20402.)

U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE (USDA)

Meat and Poultry Inspection Regulations

(Application for copies should be addressed to the Superintendent of Documents, U.S. Government Printing Office, Washington, DC 20402.)

U.S. Standards for Grades of Tomato Paste

(Application for copies should be addressed to the Chief, Processed Products Branch, Fruit and Vegetable Division, Agricultural Marketing Service, U.S. Department of Agriculture, Washington, DC 20250.)

ENVIRONMENTAL PROTECTION AGENCY (EPA)

National Interim Primary Drinking Water Regulations

(Application for copies should be addressed to the Office of Drinking Water WN550, Environmental Protection Agency, Washington, DC 20460.)

2.2 Other publications. Unless otherwise specified, the following documents of the issue in effect on date of invitation for bids or request for proposal, form a part of this document to the extent specified herein.

ASSOCIATION OF OFFICIAL ANALYTICAL CHEMISTS

Official Methods of Analysis of the Association of Official Analytical Chemists

(Application for copies should be addressed to the Association of Official Analytical Chemists, 1111 North 19th Street, Suite 210, Arlington, VA 22209.)

(Technical society and technical association documents are generally available for reference from libraries. They are also distributed among technical groups and using Federal agencies.)

2.3 Order of precedence. In the event of a conflict between the text of this document and the references cited herein, the text of this document shall take precedence.

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3. REQUIREMENTS

3.1 First article. When specified, a sample shall be subjected to first article inspection (see 4.4, 6.1 and 6.3).

3.2 Ingredients. All ingredients shall be clean, sound, wholesome, and free from foreign material, evidence of rodent and insect infestation, extraneous material, off-flavors, off-odors, and off-colors.

* 3.2.1 Beef. The beef shall be from steers, heifers, or cows and shall be derived from any combination of the following recognizable primal and sub-primal cuts: shoulder clods, chuck rolls, ribs, ribeyes, trimmed full loins, trimmed short loins, strip loins, sirloins, top sirloin butts, rounds, top rounds, knuckles, and bottom rounds (with heel out). Recognizable cuts are those which, when compared to IMPS cuts, have no more than a minor amount of lean, fat, or bone removed or included from an adjacent cut. All suitable lean meat shall be used except tenderloins may be excluded at the option of the contractor. The beef shall be in the fresh-chilled state and shall be in excellent condition, i.e., exposed lean and fat surfaces shall be of a color and bloom normally associated with the class, grade, and cut of meat, and typical of meat which has been properly stored and handled. Cut surfaces and naturally exposed lean surfaces shall show no more than slight darkening or discoloration due to dehydration, aging, and/or microbial activity. The fat shall show no more than very slight discoloration due to oxidation or microbial activity; no odors foreign to fresh meat shall be present. Changes in color and odor characteristically associated with vacuum-packaged meat in excellent condition shall be acceptable. Also, the meat shall show no evidence of freezing, defrosting or mishandling.

3.2.1.1 Boning and trimming. The beef shall be boned and trimmed to remove objectionable material such as bone, cartilage, heavy connective tissue, etc. The boneless trimmed meat shall meet the limitations specified in tables I and II.

3.2.1.2 Handling and storage of raw meat. Handling and storage of the boned and trimmed meat prior to processing into the finished product shall be in accordance with the following requirements:

a. Beef processed on the same day as boning and trimming shall not be allowed to exceed 50°F at any time prior to processing.
b. Holding in the fresh chilled state for not more than 4 days is permitted provided that the meat is maintained at a temperature not to exceed 40°F at all times prior to cooking.
c. Holding raw meat in the frozen state is permitted provided that the meat is:
   - frozen to 0°F within 72 hours after certification
   - stored at 0°F or lower at all times
   - held for not more than 120 days
   - protected from freezer deterioration and damage.
d. Meat shall not be frozen more than once prior to cooking.

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3.2.2 Tomato paste. Tomato paste shall be US Grade A paste conforming to the US Standards for Grades of Tomato Paste.

3.2.3 Beef base. Beef flavored soup and gravy base shall comply with the requirements for type I, class I, style A of EE-B-575.

3.2.4 Cornstarch. Cornstarch shall be a white, odorless, finely pulverized, modified waxy maize starch for use in canned foods. The starch shall be bland with essentially no cereal or starchy taste.

3.2.5 Wheat flour. Flour shall comply with the requirements for type III of N-F-481.

3.2.6 Vegetable oil. Vegetable oil shall comply with requirements for type B cottonseed or corn oil of JJJ-S-30.

3.2.7 Onion. Onions shall be dehydrated, minced, and practically free from such defects as outer skin, scorched material, outer root base, seed stems and harmless extraneous vegetable material. Onions shall be free flowing, pungent and a bright uniform color.

* 3.2.8 Water. Water used for ice making, formulation, and washing shall conform to the National Interim Drinking Water Regulations.

3.3 Preparation and processing.

3.3.1 Meat processing.

a. The boned trimmed beef shall be diced into approximately 3/4 by 3/4 by 3/4 inch dice.

b. The beef dice shall be heated in water until no raw portions are visible during agitation. Retain broth for gravy preparation. Any other method giving equivalent results may be used.

c. Cooking in casing of the whole cuts or chunked and formed rolls is permissible, but grinding, flaking or chopping are not acceptable.

* 3.3.1.1 Handling and storage of cooked meat. Cooked meat not processed on the same day as cooking shall be handled and stored in accordance with the following requirements:

a. Holding cooked meat in the frozen state for not more than 14 days is permitted provided that the meat is individually quick frozen or placed in a freezer at 0°F or lower within 4 hours after cooking and frozen to 0°F within 8 hours after placement in the freezer.

b. Holding cooked meat in the chilled or thawed state for not more than 72 hours prior to final processing is permitted provided that the temperature of meat does not exceed 40°F at any time.

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3.3.2 Gravy preparation. The gravy shall be formulated as follows:

Ingredient	Percent by weight
Water and/or broth	77.20
Beef soup and gravy base	6.50
Cornstarch	4.00
Wheat flour	4.00
Tomato paste (30.0% natural tomato soluble solids)	3.30
Vegetable oil	2.50
Onions, minced	2.50

NOTE: If the specific tomato solids are not available, the tomato solids that are used must be calculated to bring the solid level to that specified. Water amount shall be adjusted accordingly.

a. A slurry shall be made with the starch and part of the water. The remaining ingredients shall be mixed together and heated to approximately 140°F. The starch slurry shall be added and the final mixture heated to 180°F and held for approximately 5 minutes at this temperature.

b. The volume of final mixture shall be adjusted to compensate for evaporation loss during heating.

c. If a hot fill system is not used, the prepared gravy mixture shall be cooled immediately to a temperature not to exceed 50°F and held for not more tha hours prior to filling into pouches.

* 3.3.3 Pouch filling and processing. Each pouch shall be filled and processed such as to conform to the following requirements:

a. Filling, sealing, and thermoprocessing shall conform to the class 1 requirements of MIL-P-44073.

b. A hot fill system is permitted if compatible with the filling and clos method employed.

c. If a hot fill system is not used, the meat and gravy temperatures at time of filling shall not exceed 50°F.

d. Average net weight shall be 5.0 ounces minimum.

e. No individual pouch shall contain less than 4.8 ounces of product.

f. The average drained weight of beef dices shall be 2.3 ounces minimum.

g. No individual pouch shall contain less than 1.8 ounces of drained beef dices.

h. The filled and sealed pouches shall be thermoprocessed until a sterilization value (F_o) of not less than 6 has been achieved.

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3.4 Finished product. The finished product shall comply with the following requirements:

a. There shall be no foreign material, such as, but not limited to dirt, insect, insect part, hair, wood, paper, paint, glass or metal.

b. There shall be no foreign odor or flavor, such as, but not limited to burnt, scorched, stale, sour, rancid, musty, or moldy odor or flavor.

c. There shall be no foreign color, such as, but not limited to black, purple, blue, green, yellow, or white.

d. There shall be no ligament, tendon, opaque connective tissue, large blood vessel, or glandular material greater than 0.5 inch in any dimension which does not mash or show evidence of tissue (fiber) separation under a single application of pressure and a slight twisting motion from the convex surface of a standard teaspoon.

e. Total weight of opaque connective tissue, ligament, tendon, fat chunks, blood vessel, cartilage, gristle and glandular material shall be not more than 0.25 ounce.

f. There shall be no bone greater than 0.3 inch in any dimension.

g. The gravy shall be light brown to dark brown in color.

h. The gravy shall not be too thick, thin, or lumpy.

i. Most beef dices shall be discernable as distinct dices.

j. Texture of dices shall not be dry, tough, rubbery, or mushy.

k. Fat content of finished product shall not exceed 12 percent.

l. Salt content shall not exceed 1.2 percent.

3.4.1 Palatability. The product shall be equal to or better than the approved preproduction sample (see 6.1) in palatability and overall appearance.

3.5 Plant qualification. The meat component and the finished product shall originate and be produced, processed, and stored in plants regularly operating under Meat and Poultry Inspection Regulations of the U.S. Department of Agriculture.

3.6 Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act. All deliveries shall conform in every respect to the provisions of the Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act and regulations promulgated thereunder.

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4. QUALITY ASSURANCE PROVISIONS

4.1 Contractor's responsibility. Inspection and acceptance by the USDA shall not relieve the contractor of obligation and responsibility to deliver a product complying with all requirements of this document. The contractor shall assure product compliance prior to submitting the product to the USDA for any inspection.

4.2 Inspection and acceptance service. Product acceptability shall be determined by the USDA. The USDA will determine the degree of acceptance service necessary to assure compliance with the requirements of this document. The cost of grading and acceptance services performed by the USDA involving inspection, official documentation, and related services shall be borne by the contractor.

4.3 Classification of inspection. The inspection requirements specified herein are classified as follows:

a. First article inspection (see 4.4).
b. Quality conformance inspection (see 4.5).

* 4.4 First article inspection. When a first article is required (see 6.1), it shall be inspected in accordance with the quality assurance provisions of this document and evaluated for overall appearance and palatability. Any failure to conform to the quality assurance provisions of this document or any appearance or palatability failure shall be cause for rejection of the first article.

4.5 Quality conformance inspection Unless otherwise specified, sampling for inspection shall be performed in accordance with MIL-STD-105.

4.5.1 Component and material inspection. In accordance with 4.1, components and materials shall be inspected in accordance with all the requirements of referenced documents unless otherwise excluded, amended, modified, or qualified in this document or applicable purchase document.

4.5.1.1 Beef examination for condition and cut. All beef shall be examined in either the bone-in or boneless state for conformance to the condition and cut requirements in 3.2.1. Cuts initially examined in the boneless state shall be in the form of whole boneless recognizable cuts. Any nonconforming beef shall be rejected.

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4.5.1.2 Boned and trimmed beef examination. After boning and trimming and prior to any further processing or to any freezing, the beef shall be examined for the defects listed in table II. The lot size expressed in terms of pounds shall be declared to the AMS agent by the contractor. However, the AMS agent reserves the right to declare as a lot a portion of a declared lot, if, in his or her opinion, that portion may be out of compliance with any requirement. The sample unit shall be a minimum of 12 pounds of adjacent boneless beef. The sample size shall be as specified in table I. If all or a portion of the sample unit falls within a larger cut, the entire cut shall be examined. Failure of the beef to meet the acceptance criteria as indicated in table I shall be cause for rejection of the lot. Except for beef rejected because of freezing, defrosting, or presence of any off-condition, the beef may be reworked by the contractor and reoffered for examination. For reexamination, the sampling plan used shall be the one in table I designed for the next larger lot size than the one under which the lot was initially rejected. Beef shall not be reexamined more than one time.

TABLE I. Sampling plan for boned and trimmed beef

Lot size (pounds)	Sample size (No. sample units)	Defect categories			
		Major		Minor	
		AC	RE	AC	RE
500 or less	13	1	2	3	4
501 to 1200	20	2	3	5	6
1201 to 3200	32	3	4	7	8
3201 to 10000	50	5	6	10	11
10001 to 35000	80	7	8	14	15
Reinspection lots of 10001 to 35000	125	10	11	21	22

TABLE II. Boned and trimmed beef defects

Category		Defect 1/ 2/ 3/
Major	Minor	
151		Presence of lymph gland measuring 1.0 inch or more in any dimension.
	201	Presence of lymph gland measuring 0.5 inch or more but less than 1.0 inch in any dimension.
152		Presence of blood clot measuring 1.0 inch or more in any dimension.

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TABLE II. Boned and trimmed beef defects (cont'd)

Category		Defect 1/ 2/3/
Major	Minor	
	202	Presence of blood clot measuring 0.5 inch or more but less than 1.0 inch in any dimension.
153		Presence of bruise measuring 1.0 inch or more in any dimension.
	203	Presence of bruise measuring 0.5 inch or more but less than 1.0 inch in any dimension.
154		Presence of bone measuring 0.3 inch or more in any dimension.
155		Presence of cartilage measuring 0.5 inch or more in any dimension.
156		Presence of backstrap or other ligament measuring 1.0 inch or more in one dimension and 0.2 inch or more in a second dimension (when measured at right angles to each other).
	204	Presence of backstrap or other ligament measuring 0.5 inch or more but less than 1.0 inch in one dimension and 0.2 inch or more in a second dimension (when measured at right angles to each other).
157		Presence of heavy connective tissue (for example, on the surface of the outside round adjacent to the knuckle, along the skin surface of the strip loin, or the gracilis membrane) measuring 2.0 square inches or more.
	205	Presence of heavy connective tissue (for example, on the surface of the outside round adjacent to the knuckle, along the skin surface of the strip loin, or the gracilis membrane) measuring 0.5 square inches or more but less than 2.0 square inches.
	206	Presence of heavy connective tissue on lower edge of short plate or flank.
	207	Presence of heavy connective (abdominal tunic) tissue on the flank measuring 1.0 inch or more in any dimension

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TABLE II. Boned and trimmed beef defects (cont'd)

Category		Defect 1/ 2/ 3/
Major	Minor	
	208	Presence of membranous portion of diaphragm or membranous covering from skirt, flank, or abdominal section of short plate measuring 3 square inches or more.
158		Presence of knuckle cover.
159		Presence of kidney, pizzle eye, prepubic tendon, thymus gland, or hanging tender measuring 1.0 inch or more in one dimension and 0.2 inch or more in a second dimension (when measured at right angles to each each other).
	209	Presence of kidney, pizzle eye, prepubic tendon, hanging tender, or thymus gland measuring less than 1.0 inch in longest dimension.
	210	Presence of calcified (scratchy) periosteum measuring 2.0 square inches or more.
	211	Presence of shank, clod, knuckle, or bottom (outside) round with tendinous end showing less than 75 percent lean tissue on a cross-sectional cut surface.
	212	Presence of dehydrated surface measuring 1.0 square inch or more.
	213	Presence of discolored meat (including blood discolored neck meat) measuring 1.0 square inch or more.
	214	Presence of exposed major blood vessel measuring 1.0 inch or more in any dimension.
	215	Presence of cod, udder, kidney, or pelvic fat.
160		Presence of subscapularis muscle measuring 1.0 inch or more in any dimension.

1/ Acceptability of product with respect to the presence of foreign material (for example: glass, dirt, insect parts, hair, wood, metal) shall be made by a Meat and Poultry Inspection Operations employee. The presence of any product not in excellent condition shall cause rejection of the involved lot.

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2/ Evidence of freezing or defrosting or presence of any off-condition (including but not restricted to being off-odor, slightly sticky, gassy, rancid, sour, or showing discoloration) shall cause rejection of the involved lot.

3/ This table contains a listing of standard defects some of which may not apply to product which has been boned and trimmed from the specific cuts specified in 3.2.1. The listing of such defects does not relieve the contractor of the responsibility of complying with the requirements of 3.2.1.

4.5.1.3 Other ingredients examination. Conformance of ingredients to identity and condition requirements shall be determined by examination of pertinent labels, markings, U.S. Grade certificates, invoices, certificates of analysis, or other valid documents. In addition, each ingredient shall be examined organoleptically as necessary to determine conformance to the condition requirements. Any nonconformance to an identity, condition, or other requirement shall be cause for rejection of the ingredient lot or of any involved product.

4.5.2 In-process examination. In-process examination shall be performed to determine conformance to preparation and processing requirements. Any nonconformance revealed by actual examination or by review of records of time, temperature, and formulation or other valid documents shall be cause for rejection of the involved product.

4.5.3 Filled and sealed pouch inspection. Inspection of filled and sealed pouches shall be in accordance with the quality assurance provisions of MIL-P-44073.

4.5.4 Net weight inspection. The net weight of the filled and sealed pouches shall be determined by weighing each sample unit on a suitable scale tared with a representative empty pouch. Any individual net weight of less than 4.8 ounces shall be scored as a minor defect. The lot size shall be expressed in pouches. The sample unit shall be one filled and sealed pouch. The inspection level shall be S-3 and the acceptable quality level (AQL), expressed in terms of defects per hundred units, shall be 2.5. Results shall be reported to the nearest 0.1 ounce. In addition, the lot shall be rejected if the sample average net weight is less than 5.0 ounces.

* 4.5.5 Product inspection. The filled and sealed pouches shall be held for a minimum of 72 hours at room temperature (65° to 75°F) after completion of the thermoprocessing operation. The pouches shall be heated in boiling water, opened, and inspected for the defects indicated in table III. The lot size shall be expressed in pouches. The sample unit shall be the contents of one pouch. The inspection level shall be S-3 and the AQL, expressed in terms of defects per hundred units, shall be 1.5.

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*TABLE III. Product inspection 1/ 2/

Category	Defect
Major	
151	Drained weight of meat in a pouch is less than 1.8 ounces. 3/ 4/
152	Presence of ligament, tendon, opaque connective tissue, large blood vessel, or glandular material greater than 0.5 inch in any dimension which does not mash or show evidence of tissue (fiber) separation under a single application of pressure and slight twisting motion from the convex surface of a standard teaspoon.
153	Total weight of opaque connective tissue, ligament, tendons, fat chunks, blood vessel, cartilage, gristle, or glandular material that weighs more than 0.25 ounces.
154	Presence of bone greater than 0.3 inch in any dimension.
155	Gravy not light brown to dark brown in color.
156	Gravy too thick, thin, and/or lumpy.
157	Dices not discernable (most dices not distinct).
158	Texture, dry, tough, rubbery, or mushy.

1/ The presence of any foreign material (e.g. glass, dirt, insect parts, hair, wood, metal, etc.), foreign odor or flavor (e.g. burnt, scorched, moldy, rancid, sour, stale, etc.) or foreign color shall be cause for rejection of the lot.

2/ Product not equal to or better than the approved preproduction sample (see 6.1) in palatability and overall appearance shall be cause for rejection of the lot. (This comparision shall be performed only when deemed necessary by an AMS agent.)

3/ To determine drained weight, the pouch contents shall be emptied into a flat bottom container. Approximtely three times the volume of 180° to 212°F water shall be added to the container so as to cover the contents. The contents and water shall be agitated such as to liquify rendered fat and to remove gravy without breaking the beef dices. The contents shall then be poured into a U.S. Standard 1/4 inch sieve in a manner that will

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distribute the product over the sieve without breaking the beef dices. Sieve area shall be such that the distributed product does not completely cover all the openings of the sieve. The sieve shall be tilted slightly and allowed to drain for 2 minutes before determining the drained weight by subtracting the sieve tare weight from the gross weight. The drained weight shall be reported to the nearest 0.1 ounce.

4/ If the sample average drained weight is less than 2.3 ounces, the lot shall be rejected.

4.5.6 Product testing. The product shall be tested for fat content as specified in 4.5.6.1 and for salt content as specified in 4.5.6.2. The lot size shall be expressed in pouches. The sample unit shall be the contents of one filled and sealed pouch. The sample size shall be the number of sample units indicated by inspection level S-2. Any test result not conforming to the applicable fat or salt content requirement specified in 3.4 shall be cause for rejection of the lot.

5.6.1 Fat content testing. The product shall be tested for fat content in accordance with the Fosslet method or the Crude Fat or Ether Extract method (using petroleum ether) in the Meat and Meat Products chapter of the Official Methods of Analysis of the Association of Analytical Chemists. The results shall be reported to the nearest 0.1 percent.

4.5.6.2 Salt content testing. The product shall be tested for salt content in accordance with the Meat section in the Meat and Meat Products chapter of the Official Methods of Analysis of the Association of Analytical Chemists. The results shall be reported to the nearest 0.1 percent.

4.5.7 Packaging inspection. Inspection of packaging shall be in accordance with the quality assurance provisions of MIL-P-44073.

5. PACKAGING

5.1 Packaging. Packaging shall be in accordance with the applicable requirements of MIL-P-44073.

6. NOTES

6.1 Ordering data. Acquisition documents should specify the following:

a. Title, number, and date of this document.
b. When a first article is required (see 3.1, 4.4, and 6.3).
c. Provisions for approved preproduction samples (see 3.4.1 and 6.3).

6.2 Award of contract. Award of contracts for the product specified in this document will be limited to plants known to maintain the required sanitation conditions of 3.5.

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6.3 First article. When a first article is required, it shall be inspected and approved under the appropriate provisions of DAR 7-104.55. The first article should be a preproduction sample. The contracting officer should include specific instructions in all acquisition documents regarding arrangements for selection, inspection, and approval of the first article.

6.4 Changes from previous issue. The margins of this document are marked with an asterisk to indicate where changes (additions, modifications, corrections, deletions) from the previous issue were made. This was done as convenience only and the Government assumes no liability whatsoever for any inaccuracies in these notations. Bidders and contractors are cautioned to evaluate the requirements of this document based on the entire content irrespective of the marginal notations and relationship to the last previous issue.

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Preparing activity:

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STANDARDIZATION DOCUMENT IMPROVEMENT PROPOSAL

(See Instructions – Reverse Side)

1. DOCUMENT NUMBER	2. DOCUMENT TITLE
MIL-B-44055A	Beef, Diced, With Gravy, Thermostabilized, For Meal, Ready-To-E

3a. NAME OF SUBMITTING ORGANIZATION	4. TYPE OF ORGANIZATION *(Mark one)*
	☐ VENDOR
b. ADDRESS *(Street, City, State, ZIP Code)*	☐ USER
	☐ MANUFACTURER
	☐ OTHER *(Specify)*: _____

5. PROBLEM AREAS

a. Paragraph Number and Wording:

b. Recommended Wording:

c. Reason/Rationale for Recommendation:

6. REMARKS

7a. NAME OF SUBMITTER *(Last, First, MI)* – Optional	b. WORK TELEPHONE NUMBER *(Include A Code)* – Optional
c. MAILING ADDRESS *(Street, City, State, ZIP Code)* – Optional	8. DATE OF SUBMISSION *(YYMMDD)*

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